MAKEUP ART

Makeup for Film and Television

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

The camera sees everything: why screen makeup is built in thin layers, how continuity is recorded, and where effects makeup changes the rules.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- HD and skin
- continuity
- effects
- grooming
- the continuity photograph

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The camera does not forgive

A high-definition camera resolves texture the eye does not notice at two metres, and it reads shine as plastic. Screen makeup is therefore thinner, more matte and more precisely matched than stage makeup: a light base, concealer only where needed, powder on the T-zone, and a lip colour that matches the natural lip.

Men are made up on screen, always. A face with powder and a little concealer reads as "no makeup" on camera; an unmade face reads as shiny and tired next to a made-up one.

Continuity is the whole job

A film is shot out of order, so the makeup must be identical in scene 12 and scene 3. Photograph every actor, front and profile, in the final makeup under the same lighting, and keep the photographs with the continuity notes: base shade, blush, lip, hair, and any marks or injuries with their exact position.

Injuries need a schedule. A cut that heals over the story must be smaller in the later scenes; if nobody writes the schedule down, the cut will be large, small and large again in the order the film is shot.

Effects and the close-up

Prosthetic pieces, bald caps, scars and burns are built for the lens: the edges must disappear into the skin, and the texture must survive a close-up. Silicone, gelatin and encapsulated colour are the modern materials; spirit gum and latex are the cheap ones and they show.

Test every effect on camera before the shoot day. What looks convincing in the mirror can look like a sticker on a monitor, and the monitor is the audience.

Grooming, hygiene and the long day

Shooting days are long and hot, and makeup fails first at the hairline and the nose. Carry blotting paper, powder, cotton buds and a small bottle of remover. Never share applicators. In Nollywood conditions - heat, generators, long locations - a matte finish and a good setting spray will do more for continuity than any expensive product.

Respect the actor's skin. Ask about allergies before the first application, patch-test adhesives, and remove everything properly at the end of the day. A makeup artist who damages an actor's skin has ended a career, possibly their own.

The kit for a low-budget shoot

A workable kit for a small production: a light base and a medium base, two concealers, a translucent powder, a neutral blush, a brow pencil, a small eyeshadow palette, a lip colour close to natural, brushes, sponges, cotton buds, blotting paper, a setting spray, micellar water, tissues and a mirror with a light.

Lighting conditions decide the makeup. Daylight, tungsten, LED panels and phone lights all render colour differently, so test the day before and note what the monitor shows. A foundation that looks right under a tungsten bulb can go grey under an LED panel, and the camera will show the join at the jaw.

Work fast and clean. On a low-budget shoot the makeup artist is often also the continuity person and the person holding the reflector, so the kit should be small enough to carry and organised so that anything can be found in the

dark. Label the drawers; the day will be long.

Working with the actor

Ask before you touch. Explain what you are doing, keep the actor facing a mirror where possible, and check in during a long application. A makeup chair is a vulnerable place, and an actor who is anxious about their face will perform badly.

Know when to stop. The camera rewards a face that looks like a person; a makeup that announces itself has failed, however skilled the execution. The best compliment a film makeup artist gets is that nobody noticed.

Exercises

1. Make up a partner for a close-up, photograph the face at 50 mm and inspect it at 100 per cent on a monitor.
2. Keep a continuity sheet for a five-minute scene shot out of order, and match the makeup across three setups.
3. Build one small effect - a bruise or a scar - and test it on camera under the lighting you will actually use.

Where to read more

Penny Delamar, The Complete Make-up Artist (2002)

Rosemarie Swinfield, Stage Makeup Step-by-Step (1994)

Vincent J-R Kehoe, The Technique of the Professional Make-up Artist (1995)

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